Anatomical position and directional terms

ANATOMICAL POSITION AND DIRECTIONAL TERMS (sample notes)

Anatomical position is the reference posture for all anatomical description: the body stands erect, face and palms forward, feet flat and parallel, arms at the sides.

Key directional terms
- Superior / inferior: toward the head / toward the feet.
- Anterior (ventral) / posterior (dorsal): front / back.
- Medial / lateral: toward the midline / away from the midline.
- Proximal / distal: closer to / farther from the point of attachment (used for limbs).
- Superficial / deep: closer to / farther from the body surface.

Planes of section
- Sagittal: divides body into left and right portions. A midsagittal plane splits it into equal halves.
- Frontal (coronal): divides into anterior and posterior portions.
- Transverse (horizontal): divides into superior and inferior portions.

Body cavities
- Dorsal cavity: cranial and vertebral cavities.
- Ventral cavity: thoracic (with mediastinum), and abdominopelvic cavities.

Study tip: practise describing the location of a structure in full sentences, e.g. "the heart lies superior to the diaphragm and anterior to the vertebral column".